# THE BIG HITTER

**WHEN HARMINDER** Singh Bhullar's dream of pursuing sports couldn't take flight due to a hostile atmosphere in the Punjab of the 1980s, he vowed to help his kids realise their professional dreams. Harmanpreet's earliest memory of the sport is accompanying her father on the bike to act as a fielder in the friendly matches he played. "He'd bat lower down; all I knew was *jo chhakka maarte hain, unko bahut appreciate karte hain* (Whoever hits a six gets appreciated the most)," she says. It was an astute observation, for Harry, as she is known on the circuit, belts sixes with ease.

Until 15, Harmanpreet played cricket with boys. "Other teams' boys would complain, but when they saw me playing, they couldn't tell the difference in level," she says. If Harmanpreet comes across as fiery on field, it perhaps owes to those raucous gully matches. "You know how aggressive they can be.... If you lost, friends would tease you. So, you had to give your 100 per cent to win the next," she says. Playing with girls, she'd learn, is a different ballgame as her teammates in school complained about her. "I had to calm down and change the way I talked," she says.

Harmanpreet has now been a dominant force for the Women in Blue for over a decade. She has seen the women's game grow—from playing in empty stadiums to the team being welcomed at the Mumbai airport after finishing runners-up in the 2017 ODI World Cup. "We knew we have to do something special, only then can we attract people, money and media," she says. Harmanpreet is walking that talk. She became the first Indian—male or female—to play for the Australian Big Bash League in 2016. Under her captaincy, India has won over half of the T20Is it has played (W57, L38). Her sensational 143 n.o. against England in Canterbury last year was a reminder why she's a dangerous wielder of the axe who can change the complexion of a game. Harmanpreet is glad she has a career in sports. "It made me fearless," she says. "I wouldn't be anything without it." ■

***–Suhani Singh***

**ACCOMPLISHMENT**

**Is India's highest run-scorer in T20Is and captain of Women's IPL (2023) winning Mumbai Indians**

**HARMANPREET KAUR,** ***34***

***Captain of the Indian women's national cricket team***




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**FINAL GOAL**

**"It has been a dream to win an ICC trophy. It keeps me motivated. I want to win it for India"**

↘ **GUILTY PLEASURE** **Chhole bhature**

↘ **WHAT SHE LOVES BEST** **Spending time with family and her two Shih Tzus: Furry and Jelly. "When on tour, I miss them all the time"**